

- RAG Learning

1.5 Conservatism

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 1: Core Political Ideas, Section B

Conservatism is examined in Section B of Component 1 as a **core** idea, so every student sits it. The 24-mark question uses the command word **To what extent** (AO1 8 / AO2 8 / AO3 8) and requires you to handle *tensions within* the ideology, not merely to describe it. Marks come from knowing where conservatives disagree with each other.

Human imperfection — humans are flawed morally, psychologically and intellectually, and are therefore incapable of governing themselves by reason alone.

Change to conserve — society should adapt to changing circumstances in order to preserve what is valuable, rather than reject change and risk revolution.

Hierarchy — society is naturally organised in fixed tiers, where position is not based on individual ability alone.

Authority — those in higher positions are best able to make decisions in the interests of the whole; authority comes from above.

Atomism — society is made up of self-interested and self-sufficient individuals (also called egoistical individualism).

Noblesse oblige — the duty of the wealthy and privileged to look after those less fortunate.

Anti-permissiveness — rejection of the belief that people should make their own moral choices with no objective right and wrong.

Radical — favouring drastic political, economic and social change.

Laissez-faire — minimal government intervention in business and the economy.

Empiricism — knowledge comes from real experience, not from abstract theory.

1. Core ideas and principles

Principle	What it means	Why it follows
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Pragmatism	Act on practical experience rather than abstract theory	Because human reason is limited, theory-driven schemes produce unintended consequences
Tradition	Institutions that have survived embody accumulated wisdom	Society is too complex for any individual to redesign; what endures carries knowledge no theory supplies
Human imperfection	Humans are flawed and need restraint	Grounds the need for authority, order and law
Organic society	Society is a living whole, not a machine	Parts are interdependent, so change in one has consequences elsewhere
Paternalism	Those in authority govern in the interests of all	Follows from hierarchy plus obligation — noblesse oblige
Libertarianism	Maximum economic freedom, minimal state	The New Right strand; sits in tension with the rest

The three dimensions of human imperfection

- **Morally imperfect** — prone to selfishness, greed and the desire for power. Order and law are therefore necessary, and crime originates in human nature rather than solely in social conditions.
- **Psychologically imperfect** — people are insecure and dependent, drawn to the safety of the familiar and of settled community. This grounds the value placed on tradition, order and belonging.
- **Intellectually imperfect** — reality is too complex for any individual to comprehend fully, so grand theoretical schemes will fail. This is the ground of pragmatism and of the rejection of utopianism.

Burke's image of society as a **partnership between the living, the dead and those yet to be born** is the single most useful quotation in this topic, because it does three jobs at once: it establishes the organic view, it justifies tradition, and it explains why the present generation cannot simply override inherited institutions.

2. Differing views and tensions

	Traditional conservatism	One Nation	New Right
Human nature	Imperfect; needs restraint and guidance	Imperfect; obligation flows from position	Imperfect — but those holding power equally so, hence limit the state
Society	Organic, hierarchical	Organic; division is a danger	Atomistic — self-interested individuals
State	Authority, order, limited scope	Active where cohesion requires it	Minimal; a threat to liberty
Economy	Property as a stake in society	Mixed economy, welfare provision	Free markets, privatisation, deregulation
Method	Pragmatic, gradual	Pragmatic, reforming	Explicitly ideological
Thinkers	Hobbes, Burke, Oakeshott	Disraeli (context)	Rand, Nozick

One Nation conservatism

Disraeli warned that Britain risked becoming "two nations" of rich and poor between whom there was no intercourse and no sympathy. The response was reform — not from egalitarian conviction but because social division threatened the stability of the existing order. Noblesse oblige supplies the moral framing; self-interest supplies the practical motive. One Nation thinking dominated the party through the post-war consensus, accepting the mixed economy, the welfare state and full employment as the price of cohesion.

The New Right

The New Right fuses **neo-liberalism** (free markets, small state, individual responsibility, drawing on Hayek and Friedman) with **neo-conservatism** (social order, traditional morality, strong

defence, anti-permissiveness). Its economic programme — privatisation, deregulation, trade union reform, tax reduction — explicitly repudiated the post-war consensus One Nation conservatives had accepted.

The internal tension is worth stating explicitly in an essay: **free markets dissolve settled communities, which is precisely what the social conservatism wants preserved.**

Deindustrialisation and labour mobility did more to disrupt traditional community life than any permissive legislation. That is not a minor inconsistency — it is the reason the New Right is contested as conservatism at all, and why some argue it is a strand of classical liberalism that captured a conservative party.

3. Key thinkers

Thomas Hobbes (1588–1679) — *Leviathan* (1651). Without a sovereign power, life in the state of nature would be "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short". Humans are driven by appetite and fear and are restlessly competitive; order must therefore precede liberty, and the sovereign must be absolute and undivided, since divided authority collapses back into conflict.

The awkward bit: Hobbes reaches this by a rational contract between calculating individuals — the method of early liberalism, not Burke's reverence for what has grown up over time. He is claimed by both traditions, which tells you conservatism is defined more by its conclusions about order and imperfection than by any single method.

Edmund Burke (1729–1797) — *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790). Society is an organic partnership across generations. Change should be gradual and rooted in what exists: "a state without the means of some change is without the means of its own conservation". Loyalty is learned in the "little platoons" — family, locality, association — which stand between the individual and the state.

Note: Burke sympathised with the American colonists — he urged conciliation, not war — while opposing the French Revolution outright. The distinction he drew was between defending established liberties and remaking society from abstract theory, which is the whole of his position in one comparison.

Michael Oakeshott (1901–1990) — *On Being Conservative* (1956). Conservatism is a *disposition*, not a doctrine: a preference "for the familiar to the unknown, for the tried to the untried, for fact to mystery". Politics should be a practical activity, navigating "a boundless and bottomless sea" with no appointed destination, rather than the application of theory. Government's task is to prevent the collisions of social life, not to improve humanity.

Ayn Rand (1905–1982) — objectivism, developed in *Atlas Shrugged* (1957) and her essays. The individual should pursue rational self-interest as a moral duty; altruism imposed as an obligation is a denial of the self. The state should be minimal, confined to protecting rights — police, courts, defence. Laissez-faire capitalism is the only moral economic system because it alone rests on voluntary exchange.

Robert Nozick (1938–2002) — *Anarchy, State, and Utopia* (1974). A "night-watchman" state limited to protection, enforcement of contracts and defence. The **entitlement theory**: a distribution is just if each holding was justly acquired and justly transferred, whatever pattern results — so justice is historical, not patterned. Redistributive taxation violates self-ownership by treating some people's talents and earnings as a resource for others. His objection to Rawls is the most examinable single argument in this topic.

Exam Tip: Do not present the five thinkers as a list. The marks are in the relationships: Hobbes and Burke reach a conservative conclusion by opposite methods; Rand and Nozick begin from the sovereign individual where Burke and Oakeshott begin from society; Oakeshott's disposition sits awkwardly beside the New Right's explicit ideology. A 24-mark answer that maps those disagreements will out-score one summarising each thinker in turn.

4. Conservatism on human nature, the state, society and the economy

	Traditional	New Right
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Human nature	Imperfect — morally, psychologically, intellectually. Needs restraint and guidance from above.	Imperfect too, but the conclusion drawn is that those <i>holding power</i> are equally flawed, so the state must be limited.
The state	Necessary for order; authority flows from above; paternalistic where cohesion requires	A standing threat to liberty; minimal, confined to protection and enforcement
Society	Organic, hierarchical, bound by little platoons and mutual obligation	Atomistic. Thatcher: "there is no such thing as society"
The economy	Property gives a stake in society and security across generations; the market is accepted pragmatically	Free markets as the only moral and efficient allocation; the market is accepted as a matter of principle

Why conservatives defend private property

- It gives individuals a **stake** in society and so an interest in its stability.
- It provides **security** and independence, and can be passed between generations — connecting to the partnership across time.
- It encourages **responsibility**, since people care for what is theirs.
- For the New Right it is additionally a **right** grounded in self-ownership, which is a stronger claim than the traditional prudential one.

5. Handling a "To what extent" question

The 24-mark tariff rewards a judgement that follows from the analysis. Useful structures:

- **"To what extent do conservatives agree about the role of the state?"** — agreement that some authority is necessary; disagreement over whether it should provide. Judgement: the disagreement is about the consequences of a shared premise (human imperfection), which makes it internal rather than a split in the tradition.
- **"To what extent is conservatism a coherent ideology?"** — coherent as a disposition, incoherent as a programme. Strongest conclusion: an ideology claiming society is too complex

to redesign from theory cannot itself supply a detailed theory without contradiction, so its content is supplied by whatever it is conserving at the time.

- **"To what extent has conservatism abandoned its traditional principles?"** — the New Right's atomism and ideological method genuinely depart from Burke and Oakeshott; the reply is that adapting to circumstance is itself the tradition. Note that this reply concedes something: conservatism became ideological precisely when it wanted to change things.
- **"To what extent do conservatives agree about human nature?"** — near-complete agreement on imperfection, sharp disagreement on what follows. The best answers show that the same premise supports both an authoritative state and a minimal one.

Quick recall

- Core: pragmatism, tradition, human imperfection, organic society, hierarchy, paternalism, libertarianism
- Imperfection has three dimensions: moral, psychological, intellectual — each grounds a different conservative commitment
- Strands: traditional · One Nation (Disraeli's "two nations") · New Right (neo-liberal + neo-conservative)
- Thinkers: Hobbes, Burke, Oakeshott, Rand, Nozick — five, and Edexcel examines exactly these
- Central tension: organic inheritance (Burke) versus the sovereign individual (Nozick)
- Best single quotation: Burke on the partnership between the living, the dead and the unborn
- Burke sympathised with the American colonists but opposed the French Revolution — established liberty against abstract theory
- The New Right's own tension: markets dissolve the communities its social conservatism wants preserved